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COMPOSER VERNON DUKE, ON SEEING
PROKOFIEV PERFORM IN 1916

The early years

Prokofiev studied at the Conservatory for the next decade. He had various distinguished teachers, most notably Rimsky-Korsakov, but they left no real mark on him, as he tended to regard them as stuffy traditionalists. The most important works of his student days are his first and second piano concertos, premiered in 1912 and 1913 respectively, with himself as soloist on each occasion. Their tense, percussive muscularity contrasted sharply with the lyricism of much Russian music of the time and they provoked strong reactions—both for and against. At the premiere of the second concerto, some people are said to have booed, hissed, or walked out, but when Prokofiev played the first concerto as his graduation piece at the Conservatory in 1914, he was awarded the coveted Rubinstein Prize.

In that same year, World War I began. Prokofiev was excused military service because his father was dead and he was his mother's only support. Thus he was able to pursue his career and continued to attract attention with his self-assured personality and brashly confident music. His compositions of this time include the savagely colorful Scythian Suite (premiered in 1916)—inspired by Stravinsky's Rite of Spring and intended to create similar outrage— and Symphony No. 1 (the “Classical”